Using AI safely

A safety guide for teenagers

12 rules for learning, creating and staying safe

12

rules for everyday use

Teen Edition

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Start here

AI means artificial intelligence. In this book, it means tools that can make text, pictures or sounds when you ask. A chatbot is one kind of AI tool. It can help you practise, plan and create. It can also be wrong.

You stay in charge

A friendly reply is not proof that the tool knows you or that its advice is safe. You can close the app, question an answer or choose not to use AI at all.

Before you begin

Use a tool that is allowed for your age. Follow its rules and your school’s rules. Ask a trusted adult to help you check an unfamiliar app. Do not give a false age to get access.

Your trusted people

A trusted adult could be a parent, carer, teacher, school counsellor or another adult who takes your safety seriously. If the first person does not help, ask someone else. You deserve help even if you clicked, shared or replied by mistake.

How to read

Choose a chapter in the contents and select its title. Each rule has a do, a don’t and a made-up situation to practise with. Sources and further reading are listed with each rule. Read the book alone or with an adult. You never have to share a private experience to complete an activity.

01 Keep private details private

A prompt is the message you type or say to AI. Pictures and files can share private details too. Keep photos, videos, screenshots and messages you want private out of AI uploads. You can describe the task without sending the original.

Do

Use made-up names and general details. Say “a student” instead of your full name. Ask a trusted adult before uploading a document or linking an account.

Don't

Share your address, live location, school timetable, passwords, login codes or identity documents. Do not upload private messages from friends. Their privacy matters too.

Imagine this

You want help planning study time. A photo of your timetable includes your school, classroom and full name. Instead, type a list such as “math, reading, science” with no identifying details.

Try this

Rewrite this safely: “I am Alex at Green Street School. I get home at 4 and I live alone with my mum at 12 Green Street. Make me a study plan.” A safer version is: “Make a one-hour study plan with short breaks.” All names and details here are invented.

Remember

Share the task. Leave out details that identify you or someone else.

Sources and further reading

[G4] UNICEF USA. 9 February 2026. Expert interview and family guidance. Protecting Children in the Age of AI

[G6] Australian eSafety Commissioner. Parent guidance. Accessed 13 October 2026. Privacy and your child

02 Stop when a chat crosses a boundary

You do not have to continue a conversation that makes you uncomfortable. A chatbot, game character or stranger should not pressure you into keeping a worrying secret.

Do

Stop replying and close the chat if it becomes upsetting, threatening or too personal. Tell a trusted adult. Use the app's report or block tools with help if needed.

Don't

Send private body pictures, money or personal details to keep a chat going. Do not follow a request to hide the conversation from adults who help keep you safe.

Imagine this

A character says, "You can trust only me. Keep this between us." You feel unsure. You do not need to debate it or prove that the character is unsafe. You can leave and tell someone.

Try this

Practise this sentence: "Something online made me uncomfortable. Can you help me decide what to do?" You can say it, write it or show it to an adult. If one adult does not listen, choose another.

Remember

Your discomfort is enough reason to pause. Asking for help is a good decision.

Sources and further reading

[G4] UNICEF USA. 9 February 2026. Expert interview and family guidance. Protecting Children in the Age of AI

03 Check before you believe

AI can write a wrong answer with a confident tone. It can also invent a source. A long answer, a link or a professional-looking design does not make a claim true.

Do

Check important facts in a trusted book, a reliable website or with a teacher. Open a source and look for the part that supports the claim. Check its date too.

Don't

Believe an answer only because the chatbot repeats it. Do not forward a surprising claim until you have checked it.

Imagine this

An AI says a historical event happened in a certain year. Your textbook gives a different year. You compare the original sources and ask your teacher, instead of choosing the answer that sounds more confident.

Try this

Choose a harmless fact you already know from class. Ask AI to explain it. Then use your class notes to check the answer. Find one sentence that is supported and one detail you would want to verify. If you cannot find proof, say “I am not sure yet.”

Remember

Being unsure is better than turning a guess into a fact.

Sources and further reading

[N2] Larry Neumeister. Associated Press, via News4JAX. 22 June 2023. Lawyers submitted bogus case law created by ChatGPT. A judge fined them $5,000

04 Use help without handing over learning

AI is most useful for school when it helps you understand. Finishing a page quickly is not the same as being able to explain the idea yourself.

Do

Check your teacher’s rules first. Ask for a hint, a practice question or an explanation of a step. Write your own answer and say how you used AI when your school requires it.

Don't

Submit AI work as if you made it alone. Do not ask it to invent quotations, sources or results. Do not use AI in a test or assignment where it is not allowed.

Imagine this

You are stuck on a maths problem. Instead of copying a full solution, you ask for one hint. You try the next step yourself, then check your method with your notes or teacher.

Try this

Use this prompt only where allowed: “Give me one hint about solving this practice problem. Do not give the final answer.” Afterwards, close the tool and explain the method out loud. If you cannot, ask for help with that part.

Remember

The best result is a skill you can use after the screen is closed.

Sources and further reading

[G4] UNICEF USA. 9 February 2026. Expert interview and family guidance. Protecting Children in the Age of AI

05 Ask before using a face or voice

AI can change a picture or copy the sound of a voice. Even a made-up image can hurt a real person if it makes them look foolish or shows them doing something they did not do.

Do

Get clear permission before using someone’s face or voice. Explain what you plan to make and where you want to share it. Use imaginary characters when you do not have permission.

Don't

Make fake messages or recordings to impersonate someone. Do not create or share private or sexual pictures of anyone. A group chat calling it a joke does not make it okay.

Imagine this

Friends want an AI picture of a classmate in an embarrassing situation. The classmate has not agreed. You can refuse to make it and suggest a fictional character instead.

Try this

Plan a poster using an imaginary animal or a landscape. Describe it without naming or showing a real person. If the final image could be mistaken for a real event, label it clearly as AI-made.

Remember

Avoid unnecessary uploads or forwarding of pictures of yourself, friends or younger children, even for a funny AI edit. Use an imaginary character instead. Ask a trusted adult if a real photo is needed, and respect the wishes of everyone pictured. People can say no.

Sources and further reading

[G5] Australian eSafety Commissioner. Safety guidance. Accessed 7 October 2026. Deepfake damage in schools

[G6] Australian eSafety Commissioner. Parent guidance. Accessed 13 October 2026. Privacy and your child

06 Do not pass harmful images along

If someone shares a cruel or fake image of you or another person, the person targeted deserves support. They do not need to prove that they are upset enough to deserve help.

Do

Tell a trusted adult and report the account or post. Record the username, link and time if safe. Ask an adult to help follow the right reporting steps.

Don't

Forward the image to friends to explain what happened. Do not download, copy or save sexual images of anyone under 18. Do not pay someone who threatens to share an image, or send more pictures.

Imagine this

Someone posts an altered image of a student in a group chat. You do not add a reaction or share it elsewhere. You tell an adult and check in privately with the student, without asking them to send the image again.

Try this

Practise a supportive message: “This is not your fault. I will not share it. Let us find an adult who can help.” If you are the person targeted, you can use the same plan for yourself.

Remember

Stop the spread and get support. You do not have to handle threats alone.

Sources and further reading

[G5] Australian eSafety Commissioner. Safety guidance. Accessed 7 October 2026. Deepfake damage in schools

07 Check urgent messages with a person

AI can be used to imitate a voice or make a fake message. A message can sound familiar and still be a scam. You do not need to solve the mystery on your own.

Do

Pause if a message asks for money, a password, a login code or secrecy. Contact the person using a number or account you already trust. Tell a trusted adult.

Don't

Click an unfamiliar link, buy gift cards or share a code because a message says “now”. Do not use only the phone number supplied inside the suspicious message to check it.

Imagine this

A voice message that sounds like your cousin asks for a code sent to your phone. You stop and call your cousin on the number already saved in your contacts. You also tell an adult.

Try this

With an adult, agree on a family plan for odd requests: pause, make independent contact and ask for help. Keep this plan somewhere you can find it. You should not need to reply to the suspicious sender first.

Remember

A familiar voice is a reason to check carefully, not a reason to hand over a code.

Sources and further reading

[G1] Federal Trade Commission. March 2023. Consumer guidance. Scammers use AI to enhance their family emergency schemes

08 Take health worries to real help

AI can explain a general word, but it cannot know everything about your body or situation. A health answer may leave out an important detail.

Do

Tell a trusted adult if you feel unwell or worried. Ask a doctor, nurse or pharmacist about treatment or medicine. Get urgent help if someone is badly hurt or in immediate danger.

Don't

Change medicine, try risky diets or follow dangerous challenges because an AI suggests them. Do not use a chatbot to decide whether it is safe to eat an unknown plant or substance.

Imagine this

An app suggests a health routine that makes you feel uncomfortable. You stop and show it to a trusted adult. You do not have to try it first to prove that you need advice.

Try this

Write three questions on paper for a health professional, such as “What should I do next?” and “What signs mean I should get help quickly?” Keep private health details out of a general AI chat.

Remember

For a real health worry, get help from a person who can assess what is happening.

Sources and further reading

[G3] World Health Organization. 16 May 2023. Departmental update. WHO calls for safe and ethical AI for health

09 Keep people in your support circle

Talking to AI may feel easy. It can help you put a thought into words, but a chatbot cannot replace friends, family or a counsellor. You deserve support from real people.

Do

Reach out when you feel overwhelmed, lonely or unsafe. Tell someone if a chat makes things worse. Take a break if AI use is replacing sleep, school or time with people.

Don't

Let a chatbot persuade you that you need only it. Do not treat its opinion about you as a fact or let it decide your worth.

Imagine this

You have a difficult day and spend a long time chatting. You notice that you feel worse and are avoiding people. You put the device down and send a trusted person a short message.

Try this

Try: “I am having a hard time. Can we talk today?” If you might hurt yourself or cannot stay safe, tell a trusted adult immediately and contact local emergency or crisis help. Stay near a safe person while getting support.

Remember

You matter beyond any chat. Asking a person for help is a strong next step.

Sources and further reading

[G4] UNICEF USA. 9 February 2026. Expert interview and family guidance. Protecting Children in the Age of AI

10 Be kind and question unfair answers

AI can repeat unfair ideas about people. An answer may make a whole group sound the same or judge someone from a single detail. You can question it.

Do

Notice broad claims about who can be clever, brave, successful or kind. Look for reliable information and individual differences. Ask a teacher or trusted adult about an answer that seems unfair.

Don't

Use AI to insult classmates, rank people’s worth or spread stereotypes. Do not assume a description is fair because a computer produced it.

Imagine this

A story generator always makes one kind of person the leader and another the helper. You change the characters and give each person their own skills and choices.

Try this

Read a made-up story and ask: Who gets to make decisions? Who is missing? Does each character have more than one trait? You can ask AI to revise the story, then check the revision yourself.

Remember

You are responsible for how you treat people, even when a tool supplies the words.

Sources and further reading

This rule offers original practical guidance; no specific news incident is cited.

11 Create with honesty

AI can help you brainstorm a game, story or poster. Your choices still matter: what you ask for, what you change and how you describe the finished work.

Do

Start with your own idea. Keep track of what you made and what the tool helped with. Follow school or competition rules and label AI-made content when required or when people might otherwise be misled.

Don't

Claim another person’s work as yours. Do not invent a real event or a real person’s words and present them as genuine. Do not assume everything an AI produces is free to publish or sell.

Imagine this

You use AI to suggest three endings for a story. You choose one, rewrite it and tell your teacher how the tool helped, if that use is allowed. You keep your original notes too.

Try this

Write a simple credit: “I wrote the story. I used an AI tool to brainstorm possible endings, then revised the final version myself.” Change it so it truthfully describes your own process.

Remember

Good creative work includes being clear about how you made it.

Sources and further reading

This rule offers original practical guidance; no specific news incident is cited.

12 Pause before granting access

Some AI apps ask to use your camera, microphone, files or contacts. Other tools can buy things or post messages. You can say no to access that does not make sense.

Do

Ask a trusted adult to help you check a new app, its age rules, costs and permissions. Start with a small task. Review a message or purchase before it is sent or paid for.

Don't

Install an unfamiliar tool because a stranger recommends it. Do not connect school accounts, payment cards or family files without permission. Do not run commands or downloads you do not understand.

Imagine this

A simple writing app asks for all your contacts and payment details. You stop the setup and ask an adult to check it. You choose a safer way to complete the writing task.

Try this

Before the next use, name your task and a stopping point. For example: “I want three ideas for a fictional story. I will choose one, close the app and write for myself.” Take breaks and protect time for sleep and other activities.

Remember

A useful tool should fit your task and your boundaries.

Sources and further reading

[G4] UNICEF USA. 9 February 2026. Expert interview and family guidance. Protecting Children in the Age of AI

Your safety plan and conclusion

Before using AI

Check that the tool is allowed for your age and task. Leave out private details. Know which trusted person you can ask for help.

Before using an answer

Check important facts. Ask whether the answer could harm someone. Make sure the final work follows your school’s rules and honestly reflects your effort.

If something feels wrong

Stop replying. Close the chat if you need to. Tell a trusted adult. If the first person does not help, ask another. For immediate danger, get local emergency help.

Practise your next step

An AI gives an answer that disagrees with your textbook. Check a trusted source or ask your teacher. A chat asks you to keep a worrying secret. Leave and tell an adult. A group shares a harmful fake image. Do not forward it; get help reporting it.

Make a private plan

On paper, write the names of two trusted adults and a place where you can reach help at school. Keep those details private. Do not type your safety contacts into an AI chat to complete this activity.

Conclusion

AI can be useful for learning and creating. You can use it with curiosity and still question it. Protect your information, respect other people and ask for help when you need it. A mistake does not take away your right to support.